



enjoy steep, twisting valleys and neat terraces as far as the eye can see. Depending on when you visit, the hillside can shift in colour, from dull brown in winter to bright green in summer to glowing red and gold in fall.

My next port of call is a store that specialises in Vintage Port—the most expensive and prestigious member of the port family. Though accounting for just a fraction of total port production, Vintage Port is the Douro Valley's flagship style, produced only from a single vineyard in an exceptional year. It is produced from the best grapes, and samples are submitted to the Institute of Douro and Porto Wine two years after harvest. After being tested (and tasted) for quality assessment, vintage declarations are made. Vintage Port spends a short time ageing in the barrel—only two to three years—and is then bottled with the sediments. That is why its minimum bottle-ageing period is considered to be 15 years. The finest examples age well over 50 years. They continue to age in the bottle without getting ruined. The last Vintage was declared in 2016. It is thought that the first Vintage Port was made in 1775.

Prices for these exceptional wines can shoot through the roof. “There is a saying in Portugal: buy some bottles of Vintage Port, forget about them for 50 years, and then sell them and buy a boat,” laughs my guide. “An apocalypse can happen, but there is no way that a Vintage Port is losing value,” she adds.

So, if you happen to be in the Douro Valley, pick yourself a bottle of Vintage Port as an investment. Me? I just admire a bottle from 1885 for 90,000 euros, and wonder if anyone is actually going to drink it. **BT**